to establish a registration and clearance center for these women. I don't want them released into the wider population until every woman has been checked for disease and Dr. Capek issues a full report to Herr Reinhardt."

"They're all women?" Léa found it odd.

"That's what the telegram said. It will be the first of many passenger trains to arrive, which is why he needs additional support. Are you willing to do this?"

"Yes, of course."

"I've arranged for one of the storage rooms at the back of the train station to be cleared out and bunk beds installed. Because of the risk of disease, we'll place a tent at the far end of the platform for screening and to serve as a reception area. Between the tent and the storage room, it should provide sufficient space for the women to be housed until Dr. Capek confirms they are healthy enough to be sent on to farms and cities to work." She clicked her tongue. "They won't be staying here; we don't have the room to house them, and their labor is in demand elsewhere. But as the first entry point into *das Reich*, our responsibility is to ensure that they are ready to work." She cleared her throat. "Questions?"

"Where is the train coming from?"

"From the East—Ukraine, Russia—why does it matter, they're all *Untermenschen*." She grew impatient. "I'll leave you to inform Dr. Capek."

Léa went directly to the sick bay to tell Josef.

"She didn't say where from the East?" he asked.

"Russia and Ukraine. She said it's the first of many convoys. We need to clear them medically so they can be sent to farms and factories all over Germany. Why are they sending Russian women here?"

"It might be a sign that the Wehrmacht is in retreat, and with few men left to bring back as they've all been killed in the fighting, they're sending the women to work." He breathed deeply, like someone coming up for air. "Another turning point. This war can't go on forever."

"The Lagerführer seemed worried that the women would be—"

"Yes, we must plan for the worst."

"Our medical supplies are so low."

"We'll find a way," he said, stepping closer. For a moment, she let her mind imagine, like before, that he would take her hand. She wanted him to —despite his never having shown her any sign that he would, the desire he